

Web browser and OpenOffice—the two joys of the open source world. The local government has argued that a large amount of money is spent on buying licences in case of proprietary software, wasting a lot of the local tax payers' money. Therefore, a decision to drop Microsoft in favour of cost-effective open source alternatives seems to be a viable option.

LibreOffice coming to Android

LibreOffice needs no introduction. The Document Foundation's popular open source office suite is widely used by millions of people across the globe. Therefore, news that the suite could soon be launched on Android is something to watch out for. You heard that right! A new report by Tech Republic suggests that the Document Foundation is currently on a rigorous workout to make this happen. However, as things stand, there is still some time before that happens for real. Even as the Document Foundation came out with the first Release Candidate (RC) version of the upcoming LibreOffice 4.2.5 recently (it has been quite consistent in updating its stable version on a timely basis), work is on to make LibreOffice available for Google's much loved Android platform as well, the report says. The buzz is that developers back home are currently talking about (and working at) getting the file size right, that is, something well below the Google limit. Until they are able to do that, LibreOffice for Android is a distant dream, sadly.



However, as and when this happens, LibreOffice would be in direct competition with Google Docs. Since there is a genuine need for Open Document Format (ODF) support in Android, the release might just be what the doctor ordered for many users. This is more of a rumour at the moment, and things will get clearer in time. There is no official word from either Google or the Document Foundation about this, but we will keep you posted on developments. The recent release – the LibreOffice 4.2.5 RC1—meanwhile tries to curb many key bugs that plagued the last 4.2.4 final release. This, in turn, has improved its usability and stability to a significant extent.

RHEL 6.6 beta is released; draws major inspiration from RHEL 7

Just so RHEL 6.x users (who wish to continue with this branch of the distribution for a bit longer) don't feel left out, Red Hat has launched a beta release of its Red Hat Enterprise Linux 6.6 (RHEL 6.6) platform. Taking much of its inspiration from the recently released RHEL 7, the move is directed towards RHEL 6.x users so that they benefit from new platform features. At the same time, it comes with some real cool features that are quite independent of RHEL 7 and which make 6.6 beta stand out on its own merits. Red Hat offers Application Binary Interface (ABI) compatibility for RHEL for a period of ten years, so technically speaking, it cannot drastically change major elements of an in-production release. Quite simply put, it can't and won't change an in-production release in a way that could alter stability or existing compatibility. This would eventually mean that the new release on offer cannot go much against the tide with respect to RHEL 6. Although the feature list for RHEL 6.6 beta ties in closely with the feature list of the major release (6.0), it doesn't mean RHEL 6.6 beta is simply old wine served in a new bottle. It does manage to introduce some key improvements for RHEL 6.x users. To begin with, RHEL 6.6 beta includes some features that were first introduced with RHEL 7, the most notable being Performance Co-Pilot (PCP). The new beta release will also offer RHEL 6.x users more integrated Remote Direct Memory Access (RDMA) capabilities.

Khronos releases OpenGL NG

The Khronos Group recently announced the release of the latest iteration of OpenGL (the oldest high-level 3D graphics API still in popular use). Although OpenGL 4.5 is a noteworthy release in its own right, the Group's second major release in the next generation OpenGL initiative is garnering widespread appreciation. While OpenGL 4.5 is what some might call a fairly standard annual OpenGL update, OpenGL NG is a complete rebuild of the OpenGL API, designed with the idea of building an entirely new version of OpenGL. This new version will have a significantly reduced overhead owing to the removal of a lot of abstraction. Also, it will do away with the major inefficiencies of older versions when working at a low level with the bare metal GPU hardware.

Being a very high-level API, earlier versions of OpenGL made it hard to efficiently run code on the GPU directly. While this didn't matter so much earlier, now things have changed. Fuelled by more mature GPUs, developers today tend to ask for graphics APIs that allow them to get much closer to the bare metal. The next generation OpenGL initiative is directed at developers who are looking to improve performance and reduce overhead.

Dropbox's updated Android App offers improved features

A major update has been announced by Dropbox in connection with its official Android app, and is available at Google Play. This new update carries version number 2.4.3 and comes with a lot of improved features. As the Google Play listing suggests, this new Dropbox version supports in-app previews of Word, PowerPoint and PDF files. A better search experience is also offered in this new version, which enables tracking of recent queries, and suggestions are also displayed. One can also search in specific folders from now onwards.